

COMMENTARY OPEN ACCESS

Bringing the Universe to the University: The Place of International Students in American Academia

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Forty years ago, I arrived in the United States from Mexico, full of excitement and optimism. I was going to be an international student at the University of Arizona. I was ready to learn, explore, and immerse myself in American culture. What I found exceeded my expectations—a country that welcomed me, a system that supported me, and mentors who saw my potential. Over the course of four decades, I transitioned from student to researcher to mentor and, now, a professor emeritus at The Ohio State University—what a journey! I owe much of my professional success to the opportunities afforded to me by this country, opportunities that would have been nearly impossible elsewhere.

Lately, however, I find myself increasingly worried. Recent political developments have shaken my faith in the system that once embraced me. I am concerned that the American academic landscape is closing itself off from the international voices that have enriched it.

I still remember my first day as a postdoctoral fellow at The University of Texas at Austin in 1992. Like many international students and scholars, I attended an orientation session meant to help us understand and integrate into our new academic environment. The dean of the graduate school stepped up to the microphone and welcomed us with words that stayed with me ever since: “Welcome. Thanks for being here. Your presence brings the universe to the University.” It was not just a witty statement. It was an acknowledgment that international students and scholars play a vital role in American academia. We bring the world’s view, new ideas and perspectives, and dreams to be fulfilled. That welcoming environment is what has made American universities world-renowned centers of learning.

But that culture is now under threat. Today, international students find themselves caught in the crossfire of contentious political debates. Rhetoric that casts suspicion on outsiders is making it harder for students to fulfill their dreams of an

American education. The message is shifting from “You bring the universe” to “You are not welcomed here.”

This change is not merely discouraging—it is concerning. According to the National Foundation for American Policy, between 2000 and 2021, 38% of the United States’ Nobel Prize winners in chemistry, medicine, and physics were immigrants, many of whom first came as international students [1]. When we close the doors to international students, we close the door to progress. The strength of American higher education has come from its openness to ideas, to debate, and to people from all over the world. That openness is being eroded, and the US risks isolating itself. Fewer international students may choose to come here. Some who are already here feel unwelcome or uncertain about their future. Others must navigate complex bureaucratic hurdles simply to study and contribute.

Many international students are not visitors just passing through—we become part of the fabric of academia and society. We are researchers who advance science, clinicians who bring innovative treatments to the bedside, engineers who design the bridges of tomorrow, and scholars who expand this nation’s understanding of history, philosophy, and the arts. We become leaders, innovators, neighbors, and proud citizens.

Seeing this legacy threatened is disheartening. I came to the US with big dreams and was given the tools and opportunities to fulfill them. I want the same for today’s international students and for the generations that will follow. Academic diversity is a strength. The presence of students from around the world is not a problem to be solved. As that dean in Austin said, international students bring the universe to the university and, by extension, to the country.

If we lose sight of this truth, we risk diminishing what has made our academic institutions the world’s envy. By choosing openness over isolation, however, America can remain a place where

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talent from anywhere can flourish. I remain hopeful because the same openness that shaped my life still exists in many corners of American academia. By reaffirming our commitment to welcoming global talent, we can ensure that the next generation of young scholars has access to the same opportunities that shaped my own path.

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Reference

1. “Immigrants and Nobel Prizes: 2000-2021,” National Foundation for American Policy, October 6, 2021, <https://nfap.com/wp-content/uploads/2021/10/Immigrants-and-Nobel-Prizes.-October-2021.DAY-OF-RELEASE.October-2021.pdf>.